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WAM

MOHAMMED REVIEWS PROGRESS OF PROJECT TO DEPLOY AGENTIC AI

■ His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, in the presence of Sheikh Hamdan Bin Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Defence of the UAE, and Chairman of The Executive Council of Dubai, reviewed the progress of the new UAE government framework project, which aims to transform 50 per cent of UAE Government sectors and services within two years by deploying Agentic AI for autonomous execution and decision-making.

HORMUZ CLOSURE DEPRIVES WORLD OF 1B BARRELS OF OIL

Costs rise as global trade, energy flows hit

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

The UAE warned yesterday that the world is already facing a shortfall of one billion barrels of oil because of Iran's continued chokehold over the Strait of Hormuz, as Gulf states intensified condemnation of Tehran's actions across the region.

Dr Sultan Al Jaber, UAE Minister of Industry and Advanced Technology and Managing Director and Group CEO of Adnoc, said the prolonged closure and disruption of the strategic waterway was inflicting growing economic pain worldwide. "The world is already 1 billion barrels short because of the closure of Hormuz," Al Jaber wrote on X. "That is the arithmetic of extortion."

Strait 'held hostage'

He warned that every day the Strait is being "held hostage", costs continue to rise for families, factories, farms and economies around the globe, and called for the immediate restoration of freedom of navigation "with no conditions and no delay".

The UAE strongly condemned an infiltration attempt by members of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps on Kuwait's Bubiyan Island.

The UAE also strongly condemned what Kuwait described as an infiltration attempt by members of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) on Kuwait's strategically important Bubiyan Island. Sheikh Abdullah Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs, expressed full solidarity with Kuwait and backed all measures taken by its security authorities to counter terrorist actions.

Kuwait said the group attempted to enter the island aboard a fishing boat allegedly chartered to carry out hostile acts. Authorities said four suspected IRGC members were arrested while two others escaped after an exchange of fire that wounded a Kuwaiti serviceman.

Meanwhile, Bahrain sentenced three people to life in prison yesterday on charges of collaborating with Iran's Revolutionary Guards, while more than 20 others received prison terms of up to 10 years.

UAE calls for action

The UAE also condemned the hijacking of an oil tanker carrying Egyptian sailors off Yemen's coast after the vessel was reportedly taken into Somali territorial waters. The Foreign Ministry called for stronger international action against piracy and organised crime in key maritime corridors. Arab League Secretary-General Ahmed Aboul Gheit condemned blatant Iranian attacks on the UAE, Kuwait and Qatar's territorial waters, calling them a flagrant violation of international law.

The tensions came as Iran's chief negotiator Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf warned Washington to accept Tehran's latest 14-point proposal or face "one failure after another". At the same time, the Pentagon said the cost of the war with Iran had climbed to nearly \$29 billion.

SEE ALSO P7, 8, 9, 11, 13

UAE relief measures aid businesses, residents

Loan deferrals, fee cuts and customs relief among steps

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

The UAE has introduced sweeping financial and administrative relief measures since the Iran conflict erupted in March 2026, aiming to protect businesses, banks and residents from regional economic disruption. The measures, rolled out

by the Central Bank, Dubai authorities, regulators and lenders, focus on preserving liquidity, easing short-term financial pressure and maintaining credit flows across the economy.

Easing the pressure

The Central Bank launched a Five-Pillar Financial Institution Resilience Package on March 17, allowing temporary flexibility in loan classifications, easing capital buffer requirements and providing liquidity support to banks. UAE lenders also introduced repayment deferrals,

loan restructuring programmes, fee waivers and overdraft support, extending around Dh6.2 billion in assistance to affected customers.

Dubai also approved a Dh1 billion stimulus package effective from April, including government fee deferrals, customs relief measures, tourism fee postponements and licensing support. Authorities also eased some residency, labour and regulatory procedures to support business continuity during ongoing regional uncertainty.

SEE ALSO P6

UAE first to approve new drug for hypertension

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

The UAE has become the first country in the world to approve AstraZeneca's innovative hypertension treatment Baxfendy, as part of its efforts to accelerate access to advanced medicines and strengthen cardiovascular care.

The Emirates Drug Establishment (EDE) said the treatment, which contains the active ingredient Baxdrostat, was approved in 1mg and 2mg doses as an additional therapy for patients whose blood pressure remains uncontrolled despite conventional treatment.

Inhibiting enzyme

The drug works by inhibiting an enzyme responsible for producing aldosterone, a hormone linked to elevated blood pressure, offering what officials described as a treatment approach targeting the root causes of uncontrolled hypertension.

The approval was based on positive results from two Phase III clinical trials, BaxHTN and Bax24, which showed statistically significant reductions in uncontrolled blood pressure when used alongside standard therapies.

Fatima Al Kaabi, Director-General of the Emirates Drug Establishment, said the approval reflected the UAE's strategy to accelerate access to advanced medical solutions through a flexible regulatory framework.

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MASSIVE TURNOUT AT 10TH GULF NEWS EDUFAIR

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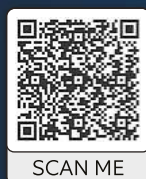
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